Baked Feta Pasta

TRIAL

Roasted tomatoes, creamy feta, spinach, garlic, and fresh herbs tossed with al dente pasta.

Yield	Prep	Cook	Total	Equipment
5 servings	15 min	40 min	50 min	3-qt baking dish

Ingredients

- 2 pints (20 oz) grape tomatoes
- 1/2 cup extra-virgin olive oil
- 1 block (7-8 oz) full-fat sheep's-milk feta, drained
- 8 oz fresh spinach, roughly chopped (about 8 packed cups)
- 2 Tbsp minced fresh parsley
- 1/2 cup reserved pasta water, used as needed
- 5 medium garlic cloves, peeled and halved
- Salt and freshly ground black pepper
- 10 oz dry medium pasta: campanelle, rigatoni, rotini, penne, bow tie, or cavatappi
- 1/4 cup thinly sliced fresh basil
- 1/4 tsp crushed red pepper flakes, plus more to taste

Method

1. Heat the oven to 400°F with a rack in the center. Set out a 3-quart baking dish.

2. Add the tomatoes and garlic to the baking dish. Toss with the olive oil and a few pinches each of salt and pepper. Place the drained feta block in the center and turn it once to coat it with oil.

3. Bake on the center rack for 30 minutes.

4. Remove the dish briefly. Move the rack to the upper third, return the dish, and raise the oven to 450°F. Bake about 10 minutes more, until the tomatoes and feta are beginning to brown.

5. While the feta finishes, cook the pasta just to al dente in 3-4 quarts of water seasoned with about 1 Tbsp salt. Time it so the pasta and roasted feta mixture finish together.

6. Reserve 1/2 cup pasta water. Just before draining, add the chopped spinach to the pasta water and submerge it; it should wilt almost immediately. Drain the pasta and spinach.

7. Using the back of a wooden spoon, mash the roasted tomatoes, garlic, oil, and feta into a rustic sauce. Add the warm pasta and spinach, basil, parsley, and red pepper flakes; toss thoroughly.

8. Add reserved pasta water a few tablespoons at a time until the sauce coats the pasta. Taste, season with salt and pepper, and serve warm.

Tips for Success

• Use a block of full-fat feta. Pre-crumbled feta has a powdery coating and does not roast or melt as smoothly; low-fat feta is also less creamy.

• Do not cut back heavily on the olive oil or tomatoes. They provide the moisture and sweetness that balance the salty, tangy feta.

• Cook the pasta only to al dente. It softens a little more when tossed with the hot sauce.

• Finish the pasta close to the time the roasting dish comes out of the oven so the noodles are warm and do not stick together.

• Add pasta water gradually. The amount needed varies with pasta shape, feta, and how juicy the tomatoes are.

Variations and Substitutions

• Protein: Fold in cooked chicken, Italian sausage, ground beef, or ground turkey after the sauce is mashed.

• Vegetables: Replace spinach with asparagus, broccoli, frozen artichoke hearts, or zucchini. Adjust cooking time for the chosen vegetable.

• Lower-carb base: Serve the sauce with zucchini noodles or spaghetti squash.

• Cheese variation: Goat cheese or cream cheese can create a different creamy sauce, but the flavor and texture will differ from feta.

Storage and Reheating

This pasta has its best texture on the day it is made. Refrigerate leftovers in a covered container for up to 3 days, or freeze for up to 2 months. The pasta will soften during storage.

AI Cookbook Note: Reheat gently in the microwave or in a skillet over medium-low heat. Add a small splash of water and toss to loosen the sauce. Cool leftovers promptly and refrigerate within 2 hours.

Troubleshooting

• Dry or tight sauce: Toss in more reserved pasta water, 1-2 Tbsp at a time.

• Grainy feta: Confirm that you used a full-fat block rather than crumbles; some feta varieties melt less smoothly than others.

• Watery sauce: Mash thoroughly, toss with hot pasta, and let it stand 2-3 minutes so the pasta absorbs the sauce.

• Flat flavor: Add black pepper, herbs, or red pepper flakes before adding more salt; feta is already salty.

Nutrition and Cost

Source estimate per serving: about 554 calories, 16 g protein, 5 g fiber, 31 g fat, 9 g saturated fat, and 495 mg sodium. Estimated ingredient cost: $2.50-$3.25 per serving, depending mainly on feta, tomatoes, and fresh herbs.

Sources

Primary: Jaclyn, Cooking Classy, “Baked Feta Pasta (TikTok Pasta),” updated May 22, 2025. https://www.cookingclassy.com/baked-feta-pasta-tiktok/

Reheating cross-check: Spice Cravings, “Baked Feta Pasta.” https://spicecravings.com/baked-feta-pasta

Food-safety note: USDA Food Safety and Inspection Service, Leftovers and Food Safety. https://www.fsis.usda.gov/food-safety/safe-food-handling-and-preparation/food-safety-basics/leftovers-and-food-safety